to ports on the eastern coast. Some Greek and Roman products would then have been re-exported to Bengal and South East Asia.

According to another ancient Greek geographer, Strabo, around 120 ships made the year-long trip to India and back in the first century AD [6]. This probably excludes Indian merchant ships that also made the trip in reverse. We know that, for most of this period, India ran a large trade surplus with the Graeco–Roman world. This resulted in a constant one-way flow of gold and silver coins. Roman writer Pliny (23–79 AD) wrote: 'Not a year passed in which India did not take fifty million sesterces away from Rome.' This is corroborated by the fact that many hoards of Roman coins have been found in India. In a world where money was based on precious metals, this one-way flow of gold and silver would have been equivalent to severe monetary tightening. At one point, the drainage of gold became so serious that Roman Emperor Vespasian was forced to discourage the import of Indian luxury goods and ban the export of gold to India. Nonetheless, as a result of centuries of trade surpluses, India accumulated a large store of gold and silver. It is estimated that even today 25–30 per cent of all the gold ever mined is held privately by Indians even though the country itself has very few gold mines of its own.

Over the centuries many groups of people came to India's western coast to trade or find refuge. Their descendants continue to live here and, in many instances, preserve ancient customs and traditions to this day. Not many people realize that India is host to one of the oldest Jewish communities in the world. It is believed that the earliest Jews came to India to trade in the time of King Solomon but, after the destruction of the Second Temple by the Romans in 70 AD, many refugees settled in Kerala. St. Thomas the Apostle is said to have landed in Muzaris at around this time and lived amongst this community. One can visit the spot where the saint is said to have landed. The descendants of his converts survive as the Syrian Christian community.

For fifteen centuries, this Christian community continued to observe old practices, including the use of Syriac, a dialect of the Aramaic language. Aramaic is the language that would have been used by Jesus Christ himself